Q. After the economic collapse of 2022, what steps were taken to bring about stability, and have they worked?

WICKREMESINGHE: First, I took over the presidency when everyone, including Sajith, was running away. Secondly, I got a team that was capable. Thirdly, I did speak with the IMF for help. And fourthly, I got the support of the people to get through the reforms—all this helped in bringing about stability.

PREMADASA: Well, Wickremesinghe has provided stability in two different ways to two different sectors. He has provided extreme stability to the Rajapaksas. He has provided excellent stability to himself and the crooks and cronies who surround him. But for the 22 million people, their lives have become smaller. The economy contracted. So, the stability he's talking about has come at an extreme cost. Nearly half of Sri Lanka is poor. They suffer from consumption poverty, food poverty, investment poverty and from loss of livelihood. So, the rulers are living in cloud cuckoo land. Close to 300,000 micro, small and medium sized enterprises have closed down. Millions have become unemployed. Enterprises have closed. This incompetent administration is sowing the seeds of future social unrest.

Q. What is your response to Wickremesinghe's charges that Sajith Premadasa and other Opposition leaders ran away from the battle when Sri Lanka was collapsing in 2022?

PREMADASA: Yes, we ran away from the rogues. We ran away from the corrupt political system, corrupt political leaders who were corrupt from top to bottom. I'm not surprised that Wickremesinghe and the Rajapaksas are very comfortable political bed fellows. So the country that was bankrupted by the Rajapaksa administration, through corruption, kleptocracy, vast scale looting of the Sri Lankan people's resources, are the very same people who are backing the president right now. This is why those who stole our assets have not been brought to book. This is the quid pro quo for support given to attain high position.

"YES, WE RAN AWAY FROM THE ROGUES, FROM THE CORRUPT POLITICAL SYSTEM. WICKREMESINGHE HAS ONLY BROUGHT STABILITY TO THE CROOKS AND HIMSELF"
—PREMADASA

WICKREMESINGHE: I don't bother to reply to him. The country knows what happened.



"I TOOK OVER THE PRESIDENCY WHEN EVERYONE, INCLUDING SAJITH, WAS RUNNING AWAY. I GOT REFORMS DONE AND BROUGHT STABILITY"
—WICKREMESINGHE

Q. Looking ahead, what is the economic vision you have for Sri Lanka? Why should Sri Lanka vote for you?

WICKREMESINGHE: To stabilise the situation and get the financial assistance from the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and the creditor nations. We still haven't got the assistance that we were promised in order to adhere to the benchmarks, that is one. Secondly, I have already passed the laws that are needed to transform our economy into an export-oriented economy. And that involves very close economic relations with India in terms of integration within some areas. Connectivity is also being focused on.

PREMADASA: Well, the simple mantra is grow, grow, grow...export, export, export and gain as much FDI as possible. That's the mantra that will alleviate poverty, generate growth, will create employment and enhance livelihoods. If people have more money in their hands, they will consume, they will invest, they will produce, they will save, they will export, so that Sri Lankan society becomes a hive of economic activity. At the same time, we must speak with our international partners to arrive at a much more reasonable package, which the silent majority of the people in this country can afford. We can't think of the minuscule proportion in our country who are super-rich. Our policy will not be to save the rich and punish the rest.